
BEARDED DRAGON

Pogona vitticeps



Beginner / Intermediate

Complete Care Package

[Quick Profile](#) · [Care Guide](#) · [Health](#) · [Quick Reference](#) · [Owner Tools](#)

BeastlyFacts

Practical care guides for curious animal lovers

Contents

How to Use This Package

How to read this manual and which pages to print first

1. Quick Profile

Species overview, facts, and cost range

2. Full Care Guide

Housing, temperatures, UVB, substrate, handling, diet, common mistakes, enrichment

3. Health & Common Issues

Red flags, MBD, impaction, appetite loss, brumation, stuck shed, glass surfing

4. Quick Reference & Checklist

Essential setup checklist and temperature targets

Emergency & Quick Targets

Printable emergency card with targets and red flags

5. Owner Tools & Decision Guides

Budget & shopping, first 30 days, symptoms, daily routine

Owner Log

Weight and daily tracking tables plus species troubleshooting

Enrichment Checklist

Setup and monthly enrichment review checklist

Glossary

Key terms used in this package

How to Use This Package

This package is a practical owner manual, not a textbook. Read the Quick Profile and Care Guide once to understand the setup. Then use the checklists, temperature targets, feeding tables, and symptom reference as working tools.

It is written for beginners and intermediate keepers who want clear standards without fluff. It is not a substitute for a reptile-experienced veterinarian. If your dragon shows red-flag symptoms, use the symptom table as a triage aid and contact a vet.

Best use: print the high-action pages and keep the rest as your offline reference.

Print these first

- Emergency & Quick Targets - page 15
- Temperature Quick Targets - page 14
- Budget & Shopping List - page 16
- First 30 Days Checklist - page 17
- Symptom Quick Reference - page 18
- Daily & Weekly Routine - page 19
- Owner Log - page 20
- Enrichment Checklist - page 21

Quick rule: correct heat and UVB fix more problems than any supplement or product upgrade.

1. Quick Profile

The inland bearded dragon is native to Australia's arid and semi-arid interior, where it basks on rocks and fence posts in open woodland and scrubland. They take their name from the expandable, spiny throat pouch - the "beard" - which darkens to black when threatened or excited. Among the most social of reptile pets, beardies are capable of forming genuine bonds with their keepers and are often described as having distinct personalities.

Native Range	Australia (central and eastern interior)
Natural Habitat	Arid woodland, scrubland, and rocky desert
Adult Size	18-24 inches (45-60 cm) including tail
Wild Diet	Omnivore - insects, vegetation, flowers, small vertebrates
Typical Lifespan	10-15 years in captivity with good care
Conservation	Least Concern (IUCN)
Difficulty	Beginner to Intermediate

Fun Facts

- Bearded dragons can change color based on mood and body temperature. They darken when cold or stressed and lighten when warm and relaxed.
 - They wave one arm as a submissive gesture to other dragons - their version of "no threat here."
 - Incubating eggs above roughly 32°C (90°F) can turn genetic males into functional females. This is a temperature-dependent sex determination mechanism.
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Cost Overview

A proper one-time setup typically runs \$400-800. This covers a 4x2x2 (or larger) enclosure, quality T5 HO UVB fixture and bulb, basking lamp and fixture, thermostat, accurate thermometers (including an infrared gun), hygrometer, substrate, hides, climbing decor, food and water dishes, and an initial veterinary exam with fecal check.

Ongoing monthly costs usually fall between \$50 and \$110, driven mainly by feeder insects, supplements, electricity for heat and lighting, and the amortized cost of annual UVB bulb replacement and a yearly wellness visit. Emergency veterinary care (impaction, MBD treatment, etc.) can be expensive, which is one more reason correct husbandry from day one is the better investment.

2. Full Care Guide

Housing & Enclosure

Adult bearded dragons need a minimum 4x2x2 ft enclosure (approximately 120 gallons). Larger is always better. Juveniles can start smaller but reach adult size relatively quickly, so starting with the correct adult enclosure from the beginning is the more practical approach. PVC or wooden enclosures with glass fronts retain heat better than all-glass tanks and are preferred by most experienced keepers. Front-opening designs make daily handling and cleaning much easier.



Example bearded dragon enclosure setup

Quick rule: measure the basking *surface* with an infrared gun - air temperature alone is not enough.

Temperature, UVB & Humidity

Bearded dragons are ectotherms - they need a hot basking surface, a real cool side, and strong linear UVB to digest food and stay healthy. Measure basking **surface** temperature with an infrared gun, not a stick-on thermometer. Exact zone targets are on the Temperature Quick Targets page (print that page).

Use a linear T5 HO UVB (Arcadia Dragon 12% or Zoo Med Reptisun 10.0 class). Coil/compact UVB is inadequate. Aim for UVI about 4.0-4.5 at the basking surface (lower for sensitive morphs). Replace the bulb every 6-12 months on a calendar - visible light does not equal UV output. Run lights 10-14 hours daily. Keep ambient humidity about 30-40%; chronically high humidity raises respiratory and skin risk.

Substrate & Furnishings

For juveniles, paper towels, newspaper, or ceramic tile are the safest choices and eliminate impaction risk. Adults can be kept on a properly maintained sand-soil mix if the dragon is healthy and well-fed. **Never** use calcium sand, walnut shells, wood chips, or gravel - at any age. Those substrates carry real impaction risk. Provide a solid basking platform, at least two hides (warm and cool side), sturdy climbing branches, and a shallow water dish. Cover three sides of the enclosure if reflections cause stress. **Never** use hot rocks.

Handling

Give a new dragon 7-14 days to settle before the first handling session. Approach from the side or below, **never** straight down from above. Support the chest, belly, and all four feet so nothing dangles. Start with short 5-10 minute sessions and increase gradually. **Never** lift by the tail. Avoid handling within about an hour of feeding.

Watch for stress signals: black or darkening beard, body flattening or puffing, open-mouth gaping, arm-waving, frantic scrambling, or freezing. End the session if these appear.

Handling session checklist

- Dragon has settled 7-14 days and is eating
 - Not in shed, not within an hour of a meal
 - Support body and feet - **never** lift by the tail
 - Keep sessions short at first; stop at the first stress signal
-

Diet & Feeding

Bearded dragons are omnivores whose diet shifts with age. Juveniles (under 12 months) should receive roughly 70-80% live insects and 20-30% leafy greens. Adults flip this ratio to 70-80% greens and vegetables with 20-30% insects.

Staple insects: dubia roaches, black soldier fly larvae (BSFL), and crickets. Offer mealworms and superworms only occasionally. Limit waxworms heavily - they are high-fat treats. Always gut-load insects 24-48 hours before feeding and dust with calcium (with D3 for juveniles more frequently). Insects should be no larger than the space between the dragon's eyes.

Staple greens: collard, mustard, dandelion, turnip greens, and endive. Rotate varieties. Offer spinach and kale only in moderation. Avoid iceberg lettuce (empty calories) and avocado (toxic). Fresh water should always be available. Many dragons absorb water better through short warm baths 2-3 times per week than from a dish alone.

Diet Ratio Snapshot

Age	Insects	Greens
Juvenile (<12 mo)	70-80%	20-30%
Adult (12+ mo)	20-30%	70-80%

Feeding Schedule by Age

Age	Frequency	Focus
Hatchling (<1 mo)	2-3x daily	Mostly tiny insects
1-4 months	2x daily	Insects + introduce greens
Juvenile (to ~12-18 mo)	1-2x daily	Still insect-heavy; greens increasing
Adult (18+ mo)	Every 1-3 days	Mostly greens; insects a few times weekly

Insects must be no larger than the space between the eyes. Gut-load 24-48 hours before feeding. Dust with calcium (with D3 more often for juveniles). **Never** feed wild-caught insects or fireflies. Avocado is toxic. Iceberg lettuce is empty calories.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- **Never** start in a tiny "starter" tank and upgrade later - buy adult size from day one.
- **Never** run heat without a thermostat.
- **Never** rely on coil/compact UVB, or keep an old linear bulb past 6-12 months.
- **Never** use calcium sand or walnut shells as substrate - at any age (impaction risk).
- **Never** guess basking temperature with stick-on thermometers - measure surface temp.
- **Never** handle heavily in the first week or during shed.
- **Never** feed insects larger than the space between the eyes.
- **Never** assume a bright UVB bulb still produces UVB.

Enrichment

Enrichment means giving your dragon real ways to climb, dig, hunt, hide, and explore. It does **not** replace correct heat, UVB, diet, or enclosure size. A solid setup comes first; enrichment builds on top of it.

Climbing and structure

Provide sturdy branches, cork, ledges, and basking platforms at different heights. Anchor anything that could collapse under an adult dragon. Rough textures help with grip and natural nail wear. Keep hides on both the warm and cool ends so the dragon does not have to choose between safety and temperature.

Dig box

A dig box is useful enrichment for many dragons and closer to a real need for gravid females. Use a container large enough for the dragon to turn and push substrate. Fill it deep enough for real digging (often 4-6+ inches for general use; deeper and more cohesive for laying females, commonly 6-12+ inches). A simple organic topsoil + washed play sand mix works well. **Never** use calcium sand. If the main floor is tile or paper, still offer a dig box so digging is not removed entirely.

Foraging and hunting

Vary food presentation: tong-feeding, short supervised live-insect hunts, and scattered greens instead of bowl-only feeding. Keep prey correctly sized and gut-loaded. Do not leave large numbers of uneaten insects overnight. **Never** feed wild-caught insects.

Supervised free-roam

Short sessions in a warm, escape-proof room can help once husbandry is correct. Start around 10-15 minutes; some calm adults do well at 15-30 minutes if they stay warm and relaxed. Block gaps under furniture, remove other pets, cords, toxic plants, and small swallowables. Supervise the whole time. End the session if the dragon cools down, panics, or becomes lethargic. Free-roam is enrichment, not a substitute for a proper enclosure. **Never** leave a dragon unsupervised to roam the house.

Visual security

If reflections or heavy room traffic trigger stress or glass surfing, cover 2-3 sides of the enclosure. Occasional layout changes are fine; constant total disruption is not.

Priority order

1. Correct heat, UVB, and space
2. Climbing + warm and cool hides
3. Dig opportunity
4. Foraging / hunting presentation
5. Supervised free-roam

Enrichment should **never** replace correct heat, UVB, or diet. It should also never mean unstable rock stacks, impaction-risk substrates, or cohabitation sold as 'social enrichment.'

3. Health & Common Issues

Most serious bearded dragon problems are preventable with correct heat, UVB, calcium, and safe substrate. Parasites (pinworms, coccidia) are common even in healthy-looking animals - annual fecal exams are recommended. Unusual skin lesions should be checked promptly. Annual wellness visits with a reptile-experienced veterinarian are strongly advised.

Red Flags - Seek Veterinary Care

- Leg trembling, soft jaw, or difficulty walking (possible MBD)
- Straining to defecate, swollen abdomen, or hind-leg weakness (possible impaction)
- Prolonged appetite loss outside of confirmed brumation, especially with lethargy or weight loss
- Yellow or necrotic skin lesions
- Persistent black beard, open-mouth breathing, or unusual discharge

What to tell the vet

Bring recent weight if you have it, a clear description of appetite and stools, your current basking temperature and UVB setup (bulb type and age), substrate, and when symptoms started. Photos or a short video of the behavior help. Mention any recent changes in diet, handling, or enclosure.

Quick rule: sudden decline in a juvenile is more urgent than the same pattern in a healthy adult. When unsure, call sooner rather than wait.

Metabolic Bone Disease (MBD)

MBD is the most common serious problem in captive bearded dragons and is almost entirely preventable. It comes from inadequate UVB and/or insufficient dietary calcium. Early signs: leg trembling, soft or rubbery jaw, difficulty walking, lethargy, and appetite loss. Advanced cases can include fractures, permanent deformities, and seizures.

Prevention

- Correct linear T5 HO UVB on a timer, replaced on a calendar (typically 6-12 months)
- Proper calcium dusting (with D3 more often for juveniles; adjust if UVB is strong and consistent)
- Basking surface temperatures in range so the dragon can digest and metabolize nutrients

What to do

- Verify UVB bulb type, age, and distance immediately
- Review calcium/multivitamin schedule
- Contact a reptile-experienced vet promptly - do not wait for advanced signs

What not to do

- Never rely on coil/compact UVB as the primary source
 - Never assume a bright bulb still produces UVB
 - Never treat suspected MBD with supplements alone and skip the vet
-

Impaction

Impaction is a digestive blockage. Common causes: unsafe loose substrate (calcium sand, walnut shells, fine particle products), prey larger than the space between the eyes, dehydration, and basking temperatures too low to digest meals. Tile or paper substrate removes most substrate risk for juveniles.

Signs

- Straining to defecate, little or no stool for days
- Swollen or firm abdomen
- Hind-leg weakness, lethargy, appetite loss

What to do

- Confirm basking surface temperature is in range
- Offer shallow warm soaks; ensure fresh water
- Remove unsafe substrate immediately if present
- Contact a reptile vet if straining, swelling, or weakness persists

What not to do

- Never use calcium sand or walnut shell substrates
 - Never feed insects larger than the space between the eyes
 - Never wait days on a juvenile that has stopped passing stool and looks unwell
-

Why Bearded Dragons Stop Eating

A drop in appetite is common and often has a clear cause. Typical reasons include:

- Brumation (seasonal slowdown - always confirm the dragon is healthy first)
- Shedding
- Gravidity in females (even without a male present)
- Stress from a new environment, overhandling, or enclosure problems
- Basking temperature too low (digestion slows or stops)
- Impaction or illness
- Simple pickiness or boredom with the same feeder insects

Juveniles have far less reserve than adults. A young dragon going more than 2-3 days without food warrants closer attention. Adults can fast longer when healthy, but any combination of appetite loss with lethargy, abnormal stool, or other symptoms should prompt a vet visit.

Brumation (Seasonal Slowdown)

Many bearded dragons slow down in cooler months. Appetite drops, they sleep more, and activity falls. This can be normal - but only after you rule out illness. A thin, lethargic, or underweight dragon is not 'just brumating.'

Before you call it brumation

- Weight is stable (not dropping week to week)
- Stools look normal when present
- No red-flag symptoms (tremors, soft jaw, discharge, strained breathing)
- Prefer a fecal check and vet exam first when unsure

If brumation is confirmed and the dragon is healthy

- Keep fresh water available at all times
- Maintain safe nighttime temps (65-75°F) - do not let the enclosure crash into the 50s
- Continue a normal light cycle unless your vet advises otherwise
- Do not force-feed a healthy brumating adult
- Weigh weekly and log it

Call the vet

- Any weight loss during the slowdown
- Juveniles fasting more than a few days (they have less reserve)
- Lethargy plus abnormal stool, discharge, or soft jaw
- You cannot confirm the dragon was healthy going into the slowdown

Stuck Shed (Dysecdysis)

Bearded dragons usually shed in patches. Most sheds finish without help. Stuck shed becomes a problem when old skin forms tight bands on toes, the tail tip, or around the eyes - those areas can lose circulation if ignored.

What to do

- Keep humidity in the normal 30-40% range and offer fresh water; short warm soaks support hydration during shed
- Provide rough surfaces (rock, wood, tile edges) so the dragon can rub loose skin off
- After a shed, check toes, tail tip, and eye area
- For mild body patches: a shallow lukewarm soak, then let the dragon rub - do not force
- Contact a reptile vet if toes/tail tip look constricted, dark, swollen, or if eye shed will not clear

What *not* to do

- **Never** pull or peel dry stuck shed
- **Never** ignore tight rings of skin on toes or the tail tip
- **Never** try to remove eye-cap shed at home if it is stuck
- **Never** soak for long periods or use hot water

Glass Surfing

Glass surfing is when a bearded dragon stands against the enclosure wall and repeatedly paddles or scratches as if trying to climb through the glass. It is a stress or restlessness signal, not play.

Common causes to check first

- Incorrect temperatures (too hot, too cool, or no real gradient)
- Enclosure too small for an adult
- Reflections that look like another dragon
- New-home settling stress in the first weeks
- Hunger, boredom, or wanting supervised out-of-enclosure time
- Gravid female searching for a dig / lay area

What to do

- Measure basking surface and cool side with an infrared gun
- Confirm adult space is at least 4x2x2 ft and the setup has real hides/climbing
- Cover 2-3 sides if reflections are the trigger
- Offer a dig box if a female is restless and may be gravid
- Brief supervised free-roam can help once husbandry is correct - never as a substitute for a proper enclosure

What *not* to do

- **Never** assume constant frantic surfing is normal long-term behavior
- **Never** ignore temperature checks because the dragon 'just wants out'
- **Never** use free-roam to excuse an undersized or incomplete setup

4. Quick Reference & Checklist

Essential Setup Checklist

- 4x2x2 ft (or larger) enclosure - front-opening preferred
- High-output linear T5 HO UVB (Arcadia 12% or Reptisun 10.0)
- Basking bulb capable of 95-115°F surface temperature (stage-dependent)
- Infrared temperature gun + digital probe thermometer
- Hygrometer (target 30-40% humidity)
- Safe substrate (tile or paper for juveniles)
- Basking platform + at least two hides
- Climbing branches and enrichment items
- Shallow water dish
- Calcium with D3 + multivitamin
- Staple feeder insects (dubia, BSFL, crickets) + gut-load food
- Leafy greens rotated regularly

Temperature Quick Targets

Zone	Target
Basking surface (adults)	95-110°F
Basking surface (juveniles)	105-115°F
Hot / warm side	~90-92°F
Cool side	75-85°F
Nighttime	65-75°F
Humidity	30-40%

Why these temperatures

Basking (stage-specific): Surface heat drives digestion and metabolism. Juveniles process large amounts of insects and grow fast, so they need the higher 105-115°F range. Adults retain heat longer and usually do well at 95-110°F.

Warm side (~90-92°F): Keeps the warm half of the gradient stable when the dragon is not directly under the basking bulb.

Cool side (75-85°F): Lets them move off the heat and self-regulate. Without a real cool zone, they cannot escape excess heat.

Night (65-75°F): A natural drop supports rest and normal cycles. Regular drops toward 55°F are too cold and raise illness risk.

Humidity (30-40%): Matches arid habitat needs. Chronically high humidity raises respiratory and skin risk. Brief overnight rises after lights-out are normal.

Emergency & Quick Targets - Bearded Dragon

Print this page and keep it near the enclosure. When something looks wrong, start here.

Quick Targets

Parameter	Target
Basking surface	95-110°F adults; 105-115°F juv
Warm side	90-92°F
Cool side	75-85°F
Night	65-75°F
UVB	T5 HO 10-12%, UVI ~4.0-4.5
Humidity	30-40%

Red Flags - Act Early

- Soft jaw, tremors, weakness (MBD)
- Prolonged appetite loss with lethargy/weight loss
- Impacted (no stool, bloated, straining)
- Labored breathing, discharge
- Severe stuck shed restricting toes/tail
- Lethargy with cold enclosure

Do This Now

- Verify basking SURFACE temp with IR gun + UVB on schedule
- Note weight, appetite, stools; photo enclosure
- Contact reptile-experienced vet promptly for red flags

5. Owner Tools & Decision Guides

Budget & Shopping List

These ranges cover a proper adult-ready setup. Buying the correct enclosure from day one costs less than upgrading later. Ongoing monthly costs typically run \$50-110 (feeders, supplements, electricity, amortized UVB and annual vet). Emergency care for preventable problems can run hundreds to thousands - correct setup is the cheaper path.

Tier	Range	What you get
Functional minimum	\$400-550	4x2x2 enclosure, basic T5 UVB, basking lamp, thermostat, paper/tile substrate, 2 hides, basic thermometers
Recommended	\$550-700	Better UVB kit, infrared temp gun, solid hides + climbing, quality thermostat, initial vet/fecal
Premium	\$700-900+	PVC enclosure, Arcadia-level lighting, full decor set, backup equipment, first wellness visit included

Shopping checklist

- 4x2x2 ft enclosure (front-opening preferred)
- Linear T5 HO UVB fixture + bulb (Arcadia Dragon 12% or equivalent)
- Basking bulb + fixture capable of 95-115°F surface temp (stage-dependent)
- Thermostat (required - **never** run heat unregulated)
- Infrared temperature gun + digital probe thermometer
- Hygrometer
- Substrate: paper towel or tile for juveniles; appropriate adult option later
- Basking platform + at least 2 hides (warm and cool)
- Climbing branches / enrichment
- Shallow water dish
- Calcium with D3 + multivitamin
- Starter feeder insects + gut-load food
- Initial vet exam + fecal check budget

First 30 Days Checklist

The first month sets long-term habits. Prioritize settling, correct heat/UVB, and monitoring over handling.

- Days 1-3: Minimal handling. Confirm basking surface with an infrared gun (95-110°F adults; 105-115°F juveniles). Confirm UVB is correctly mounted and running on a timer.
- Days 1-7: Offer appropriately sized insects and greens. Note appetite, stools, and activity. Do not panic over short appetite dips while settling.
- Week 1-2: Establish a daily light cycle (typically 10-14 hours). Spot-clean daily. Refresh water daily.
- Week 2-3: If eating well and active, begin short, calm handling sessions (5-10 minutes).
- By day 30: Weigh the dragon (kitchen scale works). Note baseline weight. Schedule or complete initial fecal check if not done at purchase.
- Ongoing: Replace UVB on a calendar (every 6-12 months), not when the bulb still looks bright.

Symptom Quick Reference

Full symptom triage table. For the one-page emergency card with targets and do-this-now steps, use Emergency & Quick Targets. This table is not a diagnosis - when in doubt, contact a reptile-experienced veterinarian.

What you see	Likely direction	First response
Leg trembling, soft jaw, weak walk	Possible MBD	Verify UVB + calcium immediately; vet soon
No stool, swollen belly, straining	Possible impaction	Check temps; warm baths; vet if unresolved
Appetite loss + lethargy / weight loss	Illness or husbandry gap	Check heat/UVB; weigh; vet if continues
Black beard + open-mouth breathing	Stress, heat, or respiratory	Check temps; reduce stress; vet if persistent
Yellow / necrotic skin patches	Possible fungal / infection	Isolate stress factors; vet exam
Only urates, no feces, for days	Constipation / dehydration risk	Hydration support; verify heat; monitor closely
Tight shed bands on toes / tail tip	Stuck shed	Warm soak + humidity check; vet if constricted
Constant glass surfing	Stress / husbandry gap	Verify temps, space, reflections; fix setup

Daily & Weekly Routine

Print this page and keep it near the enclosure. Consistency matters more than perfection.

Daily

- Check basking surface temperature with an infrared gun (95-110°F adults; 105-115°F juveniles)
 - Confirm lights/UVB are on schedule
 - Offer food on schedule for the dragon's age
 - Refresh water dish
 - Spot-clean feces and uneaten food
 - Quick visual check: eyes, limbs, beard, breathing, energy
-

Weekly

- Deeper clean of water dish and high-contact surfaces
 - Weigh juveniles more often; adults at least periodically and log it
 - Inspect for stuck shed, especially toes and tail tip after a shed cycle
 - Review feeder supply and gut-load quality
 - Wipe glass/doors and check for escaped feeder insects
-

Every 6-12 Months

- Replace UVB bulb on calendar - do not wait for visible dimming
- Annual wellness visit + fecal with a reptile-experienced vet
- Recheck thermostat accuracy and fixture condition

Last changed / logged dates (write in):

UVB bulb replaced: _____ Next due: _____

Annual vet / fecal: _____ Next due: _____

Thermostat / equipment check: _____

Owner Log - Bearded Dragon

Track weight and basic daily notes. Weight change is often the earliest warning sign. Print extra copies as needed.

Weight & Daily Log

Date	Weight (g)	Ate?	Stool?	Notes

Basking & UVB Quick Checks

- Always measure basking surface with an infrared gun - air temp alone is not enough.
- Replace UVB on a calendar (typically 6-12 months). Visible light does not equal UV output.
- If appetite drops, check surface temp and UVB age before assuming illness.
- Juveniles need hotter basking and more frequent weighing than adults.

Enrichment Checklist - Bearded Dragon

Enrichment is not optional decoration. Use this as a setup and monthly review checklist.

Setup & Ongoing Checklist

- Climbable rock / branch structure under basking zone
- Ground clutter and hides on cool side
- Supervised outdoor time in safe weather (no pesticides)
- Varied insect presentation (tong, scatter, dish)
- Fresh greens rotation daily
- Occasional rearrangement of non-basking decor
- Visual barriers so the dragon can choose cover
- Never free-roam unsupervised near hazards

Monthly review notes (write in):

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Date: _____ What changed: _____

Rule: stability for core hides/heat/water systems; novelty only in non-critical items.

Glossary

Basking surface temperature - the temperature of the rock/wood under the basking lamp, measured with an infrared gun

Brumation - a seasonal slowdown in activity and appetite in reptiles; not the same as mammalian hibernation

Dig box - a container of safe diggable substrate that lets the dragon dig without converting the whole floor

Dysecdysis - stuck or incomplete shed of old skin

Enrichment - opportunities for natural behaviors like climbing, digging, hunting, hiding, and exploring; never a substitute for correct heat, UVB, or diet

Glass surfing - repeatedly paddling or scratching along the enclosure glass; a stress or restlessness signal, not play

Gut-load - feeding nutritious food to feeder insects before offering them to the pet

Impaction - a digestive blockage, often linked to unsafe substrate or oversized prey

Metabolic Bone Disease (MBD) - bone and muscle problems caused mainly by inadequate UVB and/or calcium balance

Thermoregulation - moving between warm and cool areas to control body temperature

UVI - UV Index; a measure of UVB strength at the basking surface

This care package was compiled from BeastlyFacts research and practical husbandry standards.

Version 1.0 · August 2026

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Disclaimer: This package is for educational purposes and is not a substitute for veterinary care. Husbandry standards evolve; always verify critical health decisions with a qualified exotic/aquatic veterinarian.

No external links are included in this document.
